Climate Politics and the Geopolitics of Transition

Living in the Anthropocene

5 October 2026

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Plan for today



We know the boundaries - why don't we act on them?

Climate *politics*: who decides, how, and in whose interest?

→ *With focus on COP*

Course red thread:

- **Who is the "anthropos"?** Who causes the crisis, who bears its costs, and who gets to act?
- **What counts as knowledge, and what does it do?** From planetary boundaries to policy.
- **Where is change possible?** Institutions, markets, movements, everyday life.

We will start the session with a song



It's only four degrees, it's only four degrees
It's only four degrees, it's only four degrees
It's only four degrees, it's only four degrees
It's only four degrees, it's only four degrees

I wanna see this world, I wanna see it boil
I wanna see this world, I wanna see it boil
It's only four degrees, it's only four degrees
It's only four degrees, it's only four degrees

I wanna hear the dogs crying for water
I wanna see fish go belly-up in the sea
And all those lemurs and all those tiny creatures
I wanna see them burn, it's only four degrees

And all those rhinos and all those big mammals
I wanna see them lying, crying in the fields
(I want to see them, I want to see them burn, I want to see them)
I wanna see them burn, it's only four degrees
I wanna see them burn, it's only four degrees
I wanna see them burn, it's only four degrees

I wanna burn them, I wanna burn them
I wanna burn them, I wanna burn them

I wanna burn the sky, I wanna burn the breeze
I wanna see the animals die in the trees
Oh, let's go, let's go, it's only four degrees
Oh, let's go, let's go, it's only four degrees
Oh, let's go, let's go, it's only four degrees
Oh, let's go, let's go, it's only four degrees

I wanna burn them, I wanna burn them
I wanna burn them

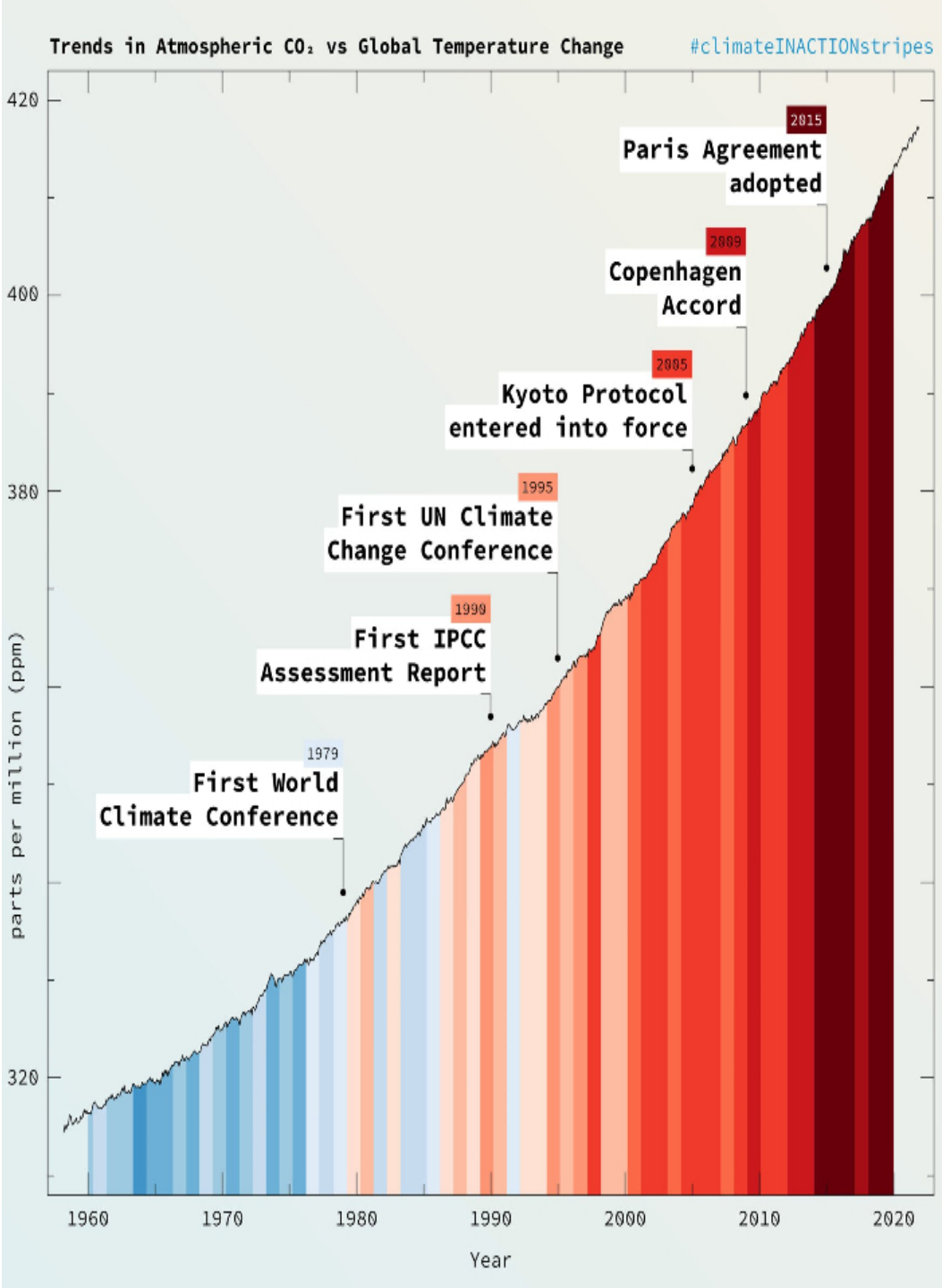
Read this review in the Guardian when the song came out
https://www.theguardian.com/music/musicblog/2015/dec/01/antony-hegarty-4-degrees-climate-change-anthem-paris-conference

Discuss with your neighbour

Pick one milestone on the stripes. With your neighbour (5 min), find out/discuss:

- What was it?
- What did it promise?
- What happened afterwards?

** You can also focus on the 1987 Montreal protocol if you would rather do that



Some key developments

- **1987: Montreal Protocol**
- **1992: UNFCCC.** → Common but differentiated responsibilities (CBDR)
- **1997: Kyoto.** Binding Annex I targets and carbon markets. US didn't ratify
- **2009: Copenhagen COP (**pledge and review, $100bn finance promise)
- **2015: Paris.** Nationally determined contributions, the 1.5°C and 2°C goals, the ratchet mechanism and the global stocktake.
- **2017–21:** US leaves and then rejoins.
- **2021: Glasgow.** From Coal "phase out" to "phase-down".
- **2022: Sharm** loss and damage fund agreed.
- **2023: Dubai.** Agreement on "transitioning away from fossil fuels".
- **2024: Baku.** $300bn, with $1.3tn as an aspiration roadmap
- **2025:** the just-transition mechanism → adaptation finance, dialogues on trade measures, and the fossil roadmap deferred.
- **2026:** US announces UNFCCC withdrawal; CBAM enters its definitive phase /// Santa Marta Declaration

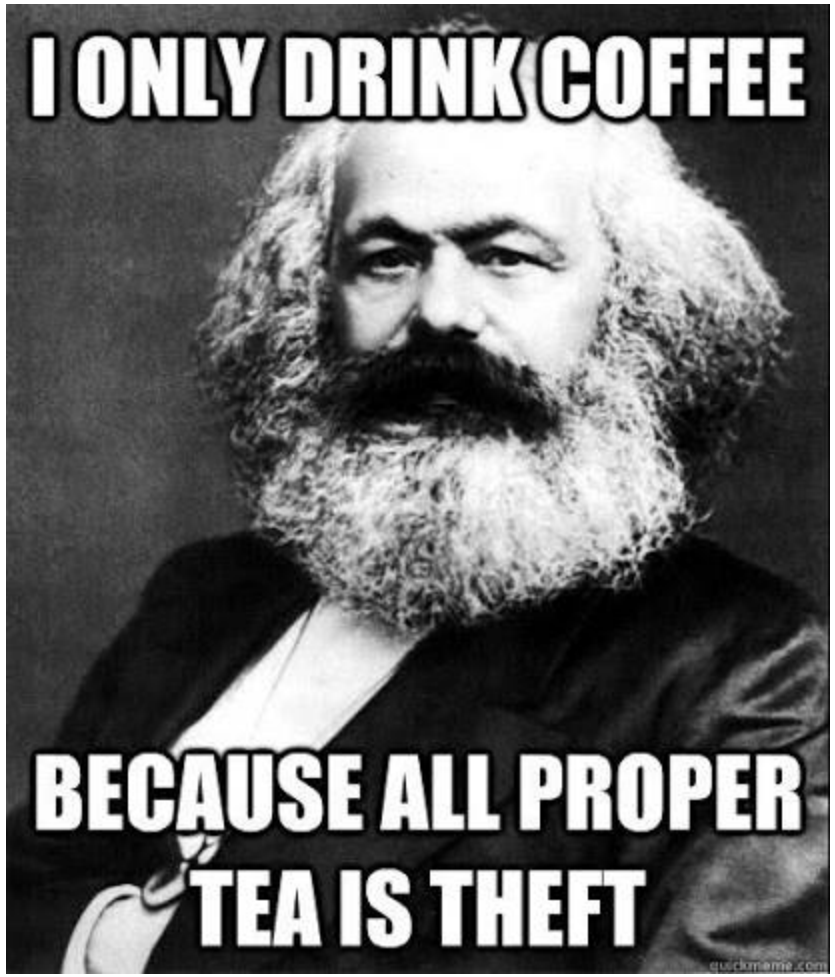
COP27 SHARM EL-SHEIKH EGYPT 2022

COP29 Baku Azerbaijan

UN-Klimakonferenz Berlin 1995



Break





Cop31

Australia and Turkey criticised for hosting UN climate conference while embracing coal

Global campaign group 350.org urges Cop31 hosts to announce a coal phase-out date and national roadmaps to get off fossil fuels

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Adam Morton *in Nadi, Fiji*

Sun 4 Oct 2026 16.00 CEST

Let's talk about COP baby

Read the article together and discuss (15 min).

1. Are there any things that are not clear?
2. What surprised you?
3. Can you recognize any themes from the readings?

Please collect three main points so you can share with the others

Plenum discussion: Bowen says coal will be displaced only when demand falls, while the supply-side argument says new supply locks in demand for decades. Who is right, and what should COP31 do about it?